

CARDIOVASCULAR ANATOMY

THE CIRCULATORY (OR CARDIOVASCULAR) SYSTEM DELIVERS OXYGEN AND NUTRIENTS TO VIRTUALLY ALL BODY CELLS, AND REMOVES CARBON DIOXIDE AND OTHER WASTES FROM THEM.

The circulatory system comprises the heart, blood vessels, and blood.

Working as a pump, the heart beats regularly to send oxygen-rich blood into tough, elastic tubes called arteries, which convey the blood around the body. The arteries divide into tiny capillaries, the walls of which are so thin that oxygen, nutrients, and other substances can pass through to surrounding cells and tissues. Waste products flow from the tissues and cells into the blood for disposal. The capillaries join and enlarge to form veins, which take blood back to the heart. In the figure shown here, vessels carrying oxygenated blood (usually arteries) appear red and those carrying deoxygenated blood (usually veins) are blue. This intricate network is some 150,000km (90,000 miles) long – almost equivalent to four times the circumference of the Earth.

